Chapter Ninety

The Withdrawal of the Ming

Between 1405 and 1455,
the Mongol north and the Da Viet
south fall to the Ming,
and great ships sail to the west,
but then victory and exploration come
to a sudden end

The Ming Empire of China had come into existence under the Hongwu Emperor, severe and ascetic; in his hands, the inner workings of the country had been entirely revamped, opposition mowed down, the remnants of the Yuan dynasty thoroughly beaten.

The ruined Yuan court, retreating to the north, hunkered down at the old Mongol city of Karakorum, but the safety of the sacred site proved an illusion. The Ming army pushed into it, sacked and burned it, and took seventy thousand men prisoner. The title of Yuan emperor survived, claimed by more and more distant relations of the long-dead Kublai Khan. But with the center of the Mongol homeland violated, the Yuan name lost the last of its cohesive power. The Mongols of the north spun apart, as the Yuan dug into its last remaining territory in the northeast, and the western Mongols reclaimed their old tribal identities. Together, four of those tribes joined into a coalition known as the Oirat.